

# Friday, 31 July 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

## 00 — WEATHER

### Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON

Overcast

25° 18°

BIRMINGHAM

Overcast

22° 12°

MANCHESTER

Light rain

19° 13°

GLASGOW

Light rain

16° 11°

## 01 — NEWS

### Today's top stories

- A drought has officially been declared across the whole of Wales, as conditions continue to worsen.**  
Wales is currently experiencing its driest July on record in almost 190 years. This declaration follows a period of exceptionally low rainfall and high temperatures.

WEATHER · UK

- Tragic news from the English Channel, where four people have died after the busiest day for small-boat crossings this year.**  
Two separate fatal incidents occurred as new figures show 752 people crossed into the UK on Wednesday. This brings renewed focus on the dangerous journeys.

MIGRATION · UK

- The Bank of England has held interest rates steady, but warns it's ready to raise them if the Iran war escalates.**  
The Bank also predicts the economy will grow more than previously forecast this year. However, significant uncertainties remain due to the ongoing conflict.

ECONOMY · UK

- England is on track for a record number of heat-related deaths this year, according to new estimates.**  
A preliminary assessment by the UK Health Security Agency suggests almost 2,900 heat-related deaths occurred during the May and June heatwaves alone. This is nearly double last year's figure.

HEALTH · UK

- A mum and her boyfriend have been jailed for the murder of a young girl, who was subjected to 'sadistic' violence.**  
Isabelle Welsh suffered horrific abuse before her death, a court heard. This deeply disturbing case has concluded with both defendants receiving prison sentences.

CRIME · UK

## What's coming up

### 1 The nominations for this year's prestigious Mercury Prize have been announced, celebrating the best albums of the year.

Olivia Dean has received a nod, while several returning nominees also feature on the shortlist. Notably, Lily Allen missed out on a nomination this time around.

**ON AIR** – Who do you think deserves to win this year's Mercury Prize?

MUSIC · COMING UP

### 2 Former England football star Shaun Wright-Phillips is set to swap the pitch for the dancefloor, joining the Strictly Come Dancing line-up!

The sportsman, who played for clubs like Manchester City, is also the son of Arsenal legend Ian Wright. He'll be hoping to impress the judges with his moves.

**ON AIR** – Do you think Shaun Wright-Phillips has what it takes to win Strictly?

TV · COMING UP

### 3 The National Theatre is preparing to mark a huge milestone this October, celebrating 50 years on the South Bank.

A free outdoor installation will tell 50 stories from the theatre's half-century. It promises to be a fantastic way to look back at their rich history.

**ON AIR** – What's your favourite memory or production from the National Theatre?

THEATRE · COMING UP

### 4 Zendaya has opened up about working with Tom Holland on their latest Spider-Man film, calling it 'easy' when you're best friends.

The couple walked the white carpet at the London premiere of 'Spider-Man: Brand New Day'. Their chemistry on and off screen is clearly a big part of their success.

**ON AIR** – Do you think working with your partner would be easy or difficult?

FILM · COMING UP

### 5 A popular Dorset festival is taking steps to ensure safety, by banning camping stoves and disposable BBQs this year.

Due to the hot weather and dry ground, these items pose a significant fire hazard. It's a sensible move to protect attendees and the local environment.

**ON AIR** – Is this a fair rule for festivals, or does it take away from the camping experience?

FESTIVAL · COMING UP

## On the schedule

### 1 **Huge news for English cricket: Stephen Fleming has been appointed as the new England Test coach, with Joe Root as captain.**

The former New Zealand captain takes the reins at a crucial time for the Test team. Root's return to captaincy will be keenly watched by fans.

**ON AIR** – Are you excited about this new era for England Test cricket?

CRICKET · UK

### 2 **Troubles are brewing for Newcastle United's Saudi owners, with manager Eddie Howe deciding to leave the club.**

Newcastle had ambitions to become a world-leading club, but spending rules are now biting. Howe's departure signals a challenging period ahead for the Magpies.

**ON AIR** – Who do you think should be the next manager of Newcastle United?

FOOTBALL · UK

### 3 **In a major stand-off, Uefa has voted to boycott World Cups if Fifa's controversial plans are approved.**

Uefa's 55 member associations are united against Fifa's proposal to sell stakes in its competitions. This could have massive implications for international football.

**ON AIR** – Do you think Uefa is right to take such a strong stance against Fifa?

FOOTBALL · GLOBAL

### 4 **Chelsea have made a significant signing, bringing in France World Cup defender Maxence Lacroix from Crystal Palace for £52m.**

Lacroix says he's 'ready to write the Chelsea story' after his big-money move. This strengthens their defence as they look to challenge at the top.

**ON AIR** – Is Maxence Lacroix the signing Chelsea needed to compete for the title?

FOOTBALL · UK

### 5 **London Spirit have secured their first win in the men's Hundred competition, beating rivals MI London in a thrilling derby at The Oval.**

Pretorius inspired Spirit to a seven-wicket victory. It was a fantastic London derby, kicking off their campaign with a crucial win.

**ON AIR** – Are you enjoying The Hundred this season? What's been your favourite moment so far?

CRICKET · UK

## Quick hits

- 1 Britons are keeping their phones for longer than ever before upgrading.**  
The average handset is now held onto for several years. The main reason cited isn't loyalty — it's the dread of moving everything across.
- 2 Cycling to the shops is up, with more people using bikes for short local trips rather than big rides.**  
Councils credit better cycle lanes. The number one cargo carried? A surprisingly heavy single bag for life.
- 3 'Quiet' holidays are the new luxury, with travellers seeking places with nothing much to do.**  
Tour operators report rising demand for remote cottages and slow trains. The number one requested feature: a reliable kettle and a view.
- 4 More households are growing herbs on the windowsill to cut grocery bills.**  
Basil and mint are the favourites. Survival rates, gardeners admit, are 'mixed' — the basil rarely makes it past a fortnight.
- 5 Britain's most-stolen supermarket item in 2026 isn't meat or cheese — it's olive oil, with theft up 220% year on year.**  
Prices have nearly doubled in two years. Some shops have fitted security tags to single bottles, others have moved premium brands behind the counter — like cigarettes.
- 6 The fastest-growing hobby of 2026 is hand-embroidery — sales of needles and thread up 180% in a year.**  
Crafters say it's the perfect 'phone detox' — slow, tactile, satisfying. TikTok is full of 20-somethings showing off custom denim jackets.
- 7 Roses are out, peonies are in — UK florists report a 200% rise in peony orders for weddings this summer.**  
Brides cite 'softer, less staged' aesthetics. Wholesale peony prices have crept up accordingly.

05 – TALKBACK

## For the phone lines

### OUR SURVEY SAID

- Q** 69% of us do **THIS** the moment we get into a hotel room.

**ANSWER:** CHECK BEHIND THE BATHROOM DOOR AND TEST EVERY LIGHT SWITCH.
- Q** Asked the most British weather complaint, the winner was **THIS**.

**ANSWER:** 'IT'S NOT THE HEAT, IT'S THE HUMIDITY.'

### TALK TOPIC

- **If you could only listen to one song for the rest of your life, what is it?**  
Talk-back: pick one. No 'depends on the mood'. Just one song forever — go.
- **What's the most British thing you've ever done?**  
Talk-back: bonus points for the apology, the queue and the cup of tea all in one anecdote.

### TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

- FACT** **Travel.** A small Welsh railway station — Llanfairpwllgwyngyllgogerychwyrndrobwlantysiliogogoch — sells more platform-ticket souvenirs than any other UK station.
- FICTION** **Made up, but believable.** A Norfolk B&B has started offering a 'no chit-chat' room for guests who want to skip breakfast small talk, marked with a polite door card and a £10 surcharge.

06 – LOTTERY

## Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

**£5.9 million**

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

**£5.9 million**

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

## Did you know?

- A flock of flamingos is called a flamboyance.
- The world's quietest room, in the US, is so silent you can hear your own heartbeat.
- Bananas are berries, but strawberries technically aren't.
- An ostrich's eye is bigger than its brain.
- The Canary Islands are named after dogs, not birds — from the Latin for dog.
- Hot water can sometimes freeze faster than cold water.
- The first oranges weren't orange — they were a greenish colour.
- A day on the Moon lasts about 29 Earth days from sunrise to sunrise.

## On this day

Day 212 of the year, 153 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Abanoub; Christian feast day: Blessed Cecília Schelingová; Christian feast day: Blessed Solanus Casey; Christian feast day: Fabius. Star sign Leo, birthstone Ruby.

### TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1974 — Emilia Fox, English actress
- 1969 — Loren Dean, American actor
- 1963 — Norman Cook (Fatboy Slim), English DJ and musician
- 1944 — Geraldine Chaplin, American actress and screenwriter
- 1943 — Lobo, American singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1940 — Stanley R. Jaffe, American film producer and director (died 2025)
- 1956 — Michael Biehn, American actor, director, producer, and screenwriter
- 1961 — Frank Gardner, English captain and journalist

### THE DAY TODAY

- 1964 — Ranger program: Ranger 7 sends back the first close-up photographs of the moon, with images 1,000 times clearer than anything ever seen from earth-bound telescopes.
- 1988 — Thirty-two people are killed and 1,674 injured when a bridge at the Sultan Abdul Halim ferry terminal collapses in Butterworth, Penang, Malaysia.
- 2012 — Michael Phelps breaks the record set in 1964 by Larisa Latynina for the most medals won at the Olympics.

### TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1975 — The Troubles: Three members of a popular cabaret band and two gunmen are killed during a botched paramilitary attack in Northern Ireland.
- 1948 — USS Nevada is sunk by an aerial torpedo after surviving hits from two atomic bombs (as part of post-war tests) and being used for target practice by three other ships.

### TODAY IN HISTORY

- 2014 — Gas explosions in the southern Taiwanese city of Kaohsiung kill at least 20 people and injure more than 270.
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2008 — East Coast Jets Flight 81 crashes near Owatonna Degner Regional Airport in Owatonna, Minnesota, killing all eight people on board.

- 1938 — Bulgaria signs a non-aggression pact with Greece and other states of Balkan Antanti (Turkey, Romania, Yugoslavia).



## A peek at tomorrow

Day 213 of the year, 152 days left in 2026. Today Armed Forces Day (Lebanon); Armed Forces Day (China) or Anniversary of the Founding of the People's Liberation Army (People's Republic of China); Azerbaijani Language and Alphabet Day (Azerbaijan); Emancipation Day is commemorated in many parts of the former British Empire, which marks the day the Slavery Abolition Act 1833 came into effect which abolished chattel slavery in the British Empire: Emancipation Day is a public holiday in Barbados, Bermuda, Guyana, Jamaica, Saint Vincent and the Grenadines, Trinidad and Tobago. Star sign Leo, birthstone Peridot.

### TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1951 — Tommy Bolin, American singer-songwriter and guitarist (died 1976)
- 1959 — Joe Elliott, English singer-songwriter, guitarist, and producer
- 1986 — Damien Allen, English footballer
- 1949 — Jim Carroll, American poet, author, and musician (died 2009)
- 1964 — Adam Duritz, American singer-songwriter and producer
- 1939 — Terry Kiser, American actor
- 1946 — Rick Coonce, American drummer (died 2011)
- 1996 — Katie Boulter, British tennis player

### THE DAY TOMORROW

- 2008 — The Beijing–Tianjin Intercity Railway begins operation as the fastest commuter rail system in the world.
- 1975 — The final act of the CSCE meeting is signed in Helsinki, Finland.
- 1988 — A British soldier was killed in the Inglis Barracks bombing in London, England.

### TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 2023 — Former US President Donald Trump is indicted for his role in the January 6 United States Capitol attack, his third indictment in 2023.
- 1964 — The former Belgian Congo is renamed the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

# Coming to cinemas

JULY 2026

FRI 31 Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026

FRI 7 Once Upon a Time in a Cinema

FRI 14 Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie

FRI 21 Mutiny; The Bride!

FRI 28 Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 4 Conjuring: Last Rites

FRI 11 Resident Evil reboot

FRI 18 The Black Phone 2

FRI 25 Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 16 Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller

FRI 23 Frankenstein (del Toro)

## On the sporting calendar

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### JULY 2026

23 JUL — 2 AUG      Commonwealth Games, Glasgow

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### AUGUST 2026

W/C 10      Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)

SAT 15      Premier League season begins (2026/27)

22–23      Belgian Grand Prix (F1)